myself now I will endeavour to recollect some of the subjects of conversation to night so that when I next write, to you, my dear Mother, I may be able to give you an account of them. But I have not kept in mind half of them. Here are a few. The Russian expedition towards Khiva— The English into Afghanistan— Lord Ellenboro's govt in India as compared with Lord Auklands— China, and some curious anecdotes about Pekin from one of the party who had a friend who had been at the Russian college there— the Suez rail road— the new chain bridge over the Neva— the American missionaries— Texas and Oregon— etc. etc.

Now if one of the cotton lords at Manchester, who would consider a poor fellow like me, scarcely fit to be footman to my Lady his wife, supposing His Lordship, a very unlikely case, had condescended to ask me to dinner. What conversation would I have heard? Perhaps an elegant oration on the anti corn law league or some raving on the registration of voters.

Russia must be in many respects a most curious country. The great mass of the people are far more barbarous than the mass of Asiatics. Education is far more uncommon amongst them than amongst the Persians. But at the same time an educated Russian is perhaps one of the most agreeable persons to meet in society because his information is so general, when I say Russian I mean men in the Russian service, who are for the most part foreigners or of foreign extraction. This remark only applies to those in the diplomatic service and some civilians. The military, particularly of the lower grades, are I think many of them not one bit better than the Persians. I was once asked by a Captain, I believe of the guard, whether England had made roads in it so that carriages could pass along or whether it was a mountainous country like Circassia where mules could scarcely travel? Whether we had wheeled carriages in England or did people travel on horses and mules and many other questions equally intelligent. When he went out of the room, the man, a Russian attaché upon whom he was calling said looking after him. "There you see a fair specimen of the officers of the Russian army." You must not imagine, my dear Mother, that in this letter I am boasting of my own acquirements. I am an illiterate man, terribly ignorant of history and many other things but I have my dear Fathers quickness in conversation, and I like the company of clever people. I often think of the way in which my dear Father when travelling would hold a conversation with any sort of man he met. And not only that, but without letting the man perceive that he was questioning him, he would get from him any information he required. This I consider one of the great talents of conversation. Some lawyers have this in a superlative degree and that is perhaps one reason why they are many of them such rising men.

Generated on 2020-09-16 00:03 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112393
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN